Silver Oaks Model United Nations, 2026

Background Guide

UNITED NATIONS
HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

Agenda: "Preventing Human Rights Violations During Armed Conflict: Assessing the Human Rights Situation of the Occupied Palestinian Territory and the Military Escalations Involving Iran."

Chairperson: Sarayu
Vice Chairperson: Darsh Pathi
Rapporteur: Sai Amrutha

Letter From the Executive Board

Greetings, delegates! We feel honoured to welcome you all to the United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC), SOMUN, 2026. We look forward to working with you all in ensuring a fruitful debate. This MUN aims at giving you a better and more thorough insight into the work and functioning of UNHRC. We have designed a Background Guide for you to start off your research process, and it will provide you with the guiding topics for your external research and background research on your country.

We urge all members of the committee to take the time to read the background guide and use it as a starting point for their research. The amount of time that you, as delegates, invest in research shapes the committee's flow, quality of debate and direction. You are the representative of your allotted country, and it is our hope that you will put in wholehearted efforts to research and comprehensively grasp all important facets of the diverse agenda.

We urge every delegate to come to the conference with an open mind, ready to meet and work with new people, and actively participate in the debate in the committee. Debate and argue solutions as well as problems and help form a thorough and effective resolution. The Executive Board will not interfere in the flow of debate unless required. Therefore, the onus to ensure that the committee does not stagnate lies on the delegates.

We will be hoping to see a lot of enthusiastic delegates. We hope to see some relevant solutions being discussed in committee, and also a lot of fun. Additionally, we hope to see a lot of discipline, regarding following the Rules of Procedure and adhering to foreign policy. We promise to make this a memorable and entertaining experience for each one of you.

Please do not hesitate to get in touch with the Executive Board at any time prior to or during the conference in case you have any queries about the agenda or the rules of procedure. We are here to help you during the conference at all times. We request the delegates to not view this conference as a zero-sum game. MUN conferences are collaborative in nature rather than competitive, and we would like to keep this spirit alive during our committee.

We look forward to seeing you and wish you the very best in your preparations.

Contact: mun2025papers@gmail.com

Regards,
The Executive Board, UNHRC
Chairperson: Sarayu
Vice Chairperson: Darsh Pathi
Rapporteur: Sai Amrutha

Position Paper

A position paper offers a concise summary of your country's viewpoint on the agenda being discussed. Your position paper should include a brief introduction followed by a comprehensive breakdown of your country's position. A good position paper will not only provide facts but also make proposals for resolutions. For **SOMUN 2026, UNHRC**, you are expected to submit a position paper on the agenda: "Preventing Human Rights Violations During Armed Conflict: Assessing the Human Rights Situation of the Occupied Palestinian Territory and the Military Escalations Involving Iran." Submitting a position paper is mandatory, and its absence will result in your disqualification from awards. It must be submitted before the deadline, and no late entries shall be entertained. Use of AI will result in the deduction of marks. ***The guidelines are as follows:***

1. Use single spacing in the Times New Roman font, size 12.

2. Include both the emblem and the national flag of your assigned country in your position paper. The emblem should be placed on the top left corner of the document, and the national flag on the top right. Ensure that both symbols are present and clearly visible.

3. Give each separate idea or proposal its own paragraph, and cite your facts and statistics.

4. Be mindful of your country's foreign policy and stick to your interests.

5. Do not plagiarize content. A plagiarism percentage of over 20% will exclude your paper from consideration. Additionally, you will be marked negatively if you include the usage of generative AI.

6. A position paper is generally no more than 2 to 3 pages long, excluding your references. It is mandatory to cite your sources.

7. The Executive Board requests the use of the MLA format for your position paper.

The format below is provided for your reference.

POSITION PAPER

Your Country

Committee Name

Agenda

Begin your position paper with a concise opening statement that highlights your country's stance on the topic. Clearly state your country's position and briefly explain the main arguments you will present in the paper.

Historical Background:

Provide a brief historical context or background information related to the topic. Highlight key events, relevant resolutions, or previous international agreements that are important for understanding your country's position. Discuss who the stakeholders are and why this is a problem worth discussing in the UNHRC. This section should demonstrate your knowledge of the issue and your country's perspective on it.

Country's Position:

In this section, outline your country's position on the topic. Clearly articulate your country's interests, concerns, and objectives related to the issue. How is it involved in the agenda? Support your position with specific reasons, facts, and references to international law or agreements. Address the main aspects of the topic and explain how your country's position aligns with or differs from other countries.

Proposed Solutions:

Offer concrete and practical solutions to address the issue at hand. Present specific policies, measures, or actions that your country believes will contribute to resolving the problem. Explain how these solutions align with your country's overall position and objectives. Consider the feasibility, effectiveness, and potential challenges of your proposed solutions.

Previous Actions and Contributions:

Highlight any previous actions, initiatives, or contributions your country has made in relation to the topic. Discuss any relevant treaties, agreements, or regional efforts your country has been involved in. Emphasize your country's commitment to addressing the issue and working towards a sustainable solution.

Conclusion:

Summarize your country's position, key arguments, and proposed solutions. Reiterate your commitment to engaging in constructive dialogue and finding a consensus-based solution that benefits all parties involved. Offer to collaborate with other delegates and express openness to further discussions during the conference.

The deadline to submit the position papers is the 29th of October, 11:00 PM, 2026. Late submissions will not be accepted. The gmail ID to submit the documents is: mun2025papers@gmail.com. Please include in the subject: Name of your country, Position Paper. Do not attach the link of any google/word document, and avoid unnecessary text in the email. Position papers will be accepted only in PDF format. Kindly do not include any other attachments.

How This Guide Is Meant To Be Used:

The following pages intend to guide you with the nuances of the agenda as well as the Committee. The Guide chronologically touches upon all the different aspects that are relevant and will lead to fruitful debate in the Committee. It will provide you with a bird's eye view of the gist of the issue. However, it must be noted that the background guide only contains certain basic information which may form the basis for the debate and your research. This guide was made to provide you with an overview on the committee, as well as our style of conducting debate. It consists of readings from various sources and we have attempted to make it as comprehensive as possible, covering various angles and viewpoints so that you have a good idea about the concepts associated with the agenda. We cannot stress enough that you need to pursue your own sources, especially because the study guides will not cover your individual foreign policies, and foreign policy compliance is very important to us. It is very likely that we, in our limited knowledge, have also omitted some crucial insights, perspectives or initiatives that are really effective or could be implemented later on. *This background guide cannot be used as a base of proof, as it is meant to be a reference only. It is not exhaustive by any means.* We hope you use it as a catalyst, and that you do not let it hinder the much needed extensive external research required for your respective portfolio. Many of the sources used in this study guide are open-source, as we have tried to bring about a balance in the way we have compiled this. Then again, there may be a chance that it may be seen as favouring any one side. We would like to assure you that it is not done intentionally, but merely the constraints of time and sources. Lastly, we would like you to note that the nature of this agenda is such that the circumstances involved in it can change on a daily basis. Thus, some of the statistics or figures that you see here may be outdated by the time you read this guide. We apologise if that is the case, but nevertheless appreciate your understanding.

What and How to Research:

Conducting thorough research is absolutely pivotal for comprehending the complex ideologies of this particular scenario. Here are some steps to guide your research and give you an idea of our moderating style:

★ The following sources of information will be deemed credible during this conference:

1) Reports published by any body/committee/affiliated body of the United Nations.

2) UN News and Reuters

3) Statistics and data reported by certain credible NGOs or statistical organisations.

4) Any other source the Executive Board may deem admissible during committee including information provided by government reports and government-funded/affiliated agency reports/articles.

★ AI is not reliable. Any usage of it will result in the deduction of points. Fair warning from the Executive Board: it is rather easy to identify AI-generated content.

★ Hierarchy of evidence: evidence can be presented from a wide variety of sources but not all sources are treated as equal. Here's the hierarchy in which evidence is categorized:

Tier 1: Includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by any of a nation's official organs or committees, or by the United Nations. Any publication, statement, or document released by a UN member state in its own capacity, or any documentation published by the UN. The evidence falling in this tier is considered the most reliable during the simulation.

Tier 2: Includes any news article published by any official media source that is owned and controlled by a UN member state, E.g.: Xinhua News (China), Prasar Bharati (India), TASS (Russia) etc. The evidence falling in this tier is considered sufficiently reliable in case no other evidence from any Tier 1 source is available on that particular fact, event, or situation.

Tier 3: Includes: any publication from news sources of international repute such as Reuters, The New York Times, Agence France-Presse, etcetera. The evidence falling under this tier is considered the least reliable for the purposes of this simulation. Yet, if no better source is available in a certain scenario, it may be considered.

This ranking is not absolute, and will be reviewed in committee sessions based upon the prevailing circumstances. It is in no way an objective ranking of truthfulness in every context. It is strictly for the objective of uniformity in this committee. Cross-check facts from a multitude of sources to ensure utmost accuracy. In order to raise Points of Order

(these will be explained thoroughly in the committee, along with the rest of the Rules of Procedure) that will be upheld, it is extremely important to produce a reliable and consistent source.

★ If you are unsure about the foreign policy of your country, find the website for the foreign ministry of the country you have been assigned alongside the "Permanent Mission of your country to the United Nations" website. Search for a key term relating to this agenda. This should give you statements from recent press conferences or UN committee sessions that can act as valuable sources of information in forming a position. Additionally, you can rely on the press releases of your country's government and the speeches made by your head of government to get a better grasp of your stance.

★ The UN Charter plays an important role here. Keep a copy of this document in either PDF or physical format as this document, an official document made by the United Nations, contains useful information. It outlines the core principles of the UN and lays out the mandate of the six principal organs that it undertakes. Take time to first research the mandates and functions of the committee you have been assigned, here, UNHRC.

★ Take sources from multiple stakeholders into consideration, as well as international viewpoints to establish a balanced understanding.

★ Pay attention to human rights reports, political development, and overall international diplomatic endeavours related to the region. Any recent developments related to events such as a ceasefire would be relevant.

★ The Executive Board intends to follow the Rules of Procedures enacted in the UNA-USA format, with variations per the committee's needs.

Introduction to the Committee:

The Human Rights Council:

Human rights are inalienable entitlements established not merely by law, but by human birthright. The history of human rights has been shaped by all major world events and the struggle for dignity, freedom, and equality everywhere. However, it was only with the signing of the Charter of the United Nations (1945), the subsequent establishment of the United Nations (UN) in the shadow of World War II, and the call to "reaffirm faith in fundamental human rights," where human rights finally achieved formal, universal recognition.

The UN has remained committed to "promoting and encouraging respect for human rights and for fundamental freedoms for all" through charter-based and treaty-based mechanisms. Charter-based mechanisms derive from the provisions of the Charter, most commonly as subsidiary bodies like the Human Rights Council. Treaty-based mechanisms arise from international human rights treaties and the treaty bodies established to monitor states' implementation of their obligations under those treaties.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR, 1948) was adopted by the General Assembly as a "common standard of achievement" for all peoples and countries to pursue the protection and promotion of human rights. The International Bill of Human Rights comprises the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), and the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), together with the two Optional Protocols to the ICCPR. It was not just these documents which guided human rights in the UN system, but also the Commission on Human Rights, which manifested as "the main subsidiary organ of the United Nations dealing with human rights."

The Commission had functioned for 60 years as the principal body concerned with the defense of human rights within the universal protection system. It was responsible for the creation of the aforementioned principal human rights treaties and the development of the non-conventional human rights protection mechanisms, including the 1503 complaint procedure and the special procedures (special rapporteurs, working groups, among others). This Commission was then dissolved and replaced by the United Nations Human Rights Council which was established in 2006 by the General Assembly's Resolution 60/251.

MANDATE:

Recognising the need to preserve and build on the Commission's achievements and to redress its shortcomings, the HRC was created to ensure stronger system-wide coherence and preserve the value of human life "in larger freedom." The Council was charged with, inter alia, assuming the roles and responsibilities of the Commission, promoting the full implementation of human rights obligations, responding to human rights emergencies, undertaking a universal periodic review, and making recommendations to States and the General Assembly (GA). The Human Rights Council consists of different mechanisms and entities, as set out in the Council's 'Institution-building package' (Resolution 5/1) of 2007. These include the Universal Periodic Review (UPR), a State-led mechanism that regularly assesses the human rights situations of all United Nations Member States, the Special Procedures, the Advisory Committee, the Complaint Procedure, HRC mandated investigations, open-ended intergovernmental working groups, as well as forums. Working within the bounds of this mandate is crucial in any simulation of the UNHRC. Here attached are the mandates of the CHR and UNHRC:

Resolution 48/141
Resolution 60/251
Resolution 16/21
Resolution 5/1

Introduction to the Agenda:

Agenda: "Preventing Human Rights Violations During Armed Conflict: Assessing the Human Rights Situation of the Occupied Palestinian Territory and the Military Escalations Involving Iran."

The dramatic reality of contemporary conflicts and related violent crises is the heavy toll of armed violence on civilians. The changing nature of conflict has brought about strategies and tactics that have made civilians and vulnerable groups in society the specific target of attack. In a context of evolving forms of 'war' and other forms of violent conflict, the protection of human rights faces unprecedented challenges and poses essential dilemmas. Contemporary conflicts usually emerge in a diversity of contexts, and are characterised by multiple causes, dynamics, levels and actors that have been traditionally discussed in the field of conflict analysis. The theoretical debate indicates that there is no prototypical root cause leading to violence. Nonetheless, a crucial dimension of the factors leading to violence is the lack of satisfaction of human needs, and of the protection and fulfillment of human rights, which analysts have connected to causes of violent conflict. Even if human rights violations are not the only factor propelling violent conflict, research suggests that human rights violations and the protection of

human rights are intimately linked to the patterns of contemporary conflict in a number of ways, which compels the need to deal with human rights and humanitarian law obligations by the international efforts aimed at conflict resolution.

Human rights violations emerge as a result of violent conflict. Conflicts that have grown out of concern to promote a political or ideological agenda, or to promote the welfare of one or more identity groups, or over access to resources have commonly resulted not only in great loss of human life on the battlefield, but also in wide-scale killing and displacement of civilians, and gross and systematic human rights violations. Contemporary conflicts are characterized by a growing trend of 'one-side violence' which is inflicted on civilians. In the majority of occasions it involves a conscious choice to harm civilians, although it can have other objectives beyond just injuring or killing civilians because it may be intended to terrorise the population. Human rights violations may overlap with the violation of international humanitarian law, and could also include torture and disappearances, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and even genocide. Human rights violations can be both causes and consequences of conflict, intertwined among other factors. Manifestations of violent conflict might affect civil and political rights; excessive use of force by the police, intimidation of political opponents, rape, summary executions, disappearances, torture and censorship, the destruction of infrastructure such as schools and health clinics and the displacement of civilian populations.

We also observe violations of human rights as causes of conflict: exclusion of minorities, uneven access to resources, discrimination and non-participation in public affairs. They represent situations where denial of human rights are embedded in the structures of society and governance, in terms of how the State is organised, how institutions operate and how society functions. Most of contemporary violent conflicts are internal in scope and pose the challenge of regulating the activities of the non-state actors (NSAs), including non-state armed groups (NSAGs), groups designated as rebels or opposition groups etc, in particular in view of their impact on human rights and their role as perpetrators of human rights violations in armed conflict and other violent settings.

Human rights protection and accountability are also important demands that parties to violent conflict make during diplomatic negotiations. Human rights may emerge as a central concern in negotiations in a number of ways highlighting antagonist positions on the negotiation table and even becoming serious obstacles to peace negotiations. In particular, it is common to see that perpetrators of serious human rights violations and international crimes, whether part of armed groups or the government, press for blanket amnesties or at least for their own protection raising problems of impunity. In these settings there remain important tensions between the pursuit of accountability and the pursuit of peace. As delegates, you may refer to recent peace agreements to confirm that either they set accountability to one side, or explicitly grant amnesties for one or more parties. In this regard, it becomes crucial for you to navigate the inherent tension between

pursuing prevention and upholding accountability for human rights violations. Ultimately, as it is contended also that the absence of accountability for human rights violations often does not result in the hoped-for benefits and may hamper long-term peacebuilding, the delegates of this committee must grapple with extending beyond acknowledging human rights violations and attempt to centre your discussions around the active protection of human rights and civil liberties.

As for the particular regions in this agenda, the concern for the protection of human rights is grave. The Occupied Palestinian Territory faces a protracted protection and political crisis characterized by more than 59 years of Israeli military occupation, over 19 years of the Gaza blockade, internal Palestinian divisions, lack of adherence to international humanitarian and human rights law, and recurrent escalations of hostilities between Israeli security forces and Palestinian armed groups. The hostilities which commenced in October 2023 resulted in unprecedented levels of destruction and suffering, including tens of thousands of Palestinian casualties, hundreds of Israeli casualties, and according to human rights watch, approximately 251 people were abducted from Israel and taken hostage to Gaza during the 7 October 2023 attacks. Nearly all of Gaza's current population of 2.1 million people has been displaced (Humanitarian Situation Update #187 – Gaza Strip – OCHA), lacking access to sufficient shelter, food, life-saving medical services, clean water, education and livelihoods. In the West Bank, Palestinians in Area C, East Jerusalem and the H2 area of Hebron city continue to face a coercive environment due to a range of longstanding Israeli policies and practices, which have intensified since October 2023. The restrictive and discriminatory planning regime applied in Area C and in East Jerusalem prevents Palestinians from addressing basic housing, livelihoods, and service needs. Further components of the coercive environment of continuing concern are excessive use of force, demolitions, evictions, settlement expansion, and settler-related violence. Combined, they drive insecurity, deprivation of basic human rights and humanitarian needs among Palestinians. At the same time, civilians in the Gaza strip also face human rights abuses from Hamas-affiliated security forces. This is apparent in the reports of authorities and forces affiliated with Hamas in the occupied Gaza Strip carrying out extrajudicial executions, and violating the people's right to protest. A ceasefire agreement in October 2025 offered hope and the adoption of UN Security Council Resolution 2803 provides an opportunity to consolidate peace, but this is yet to be translated into tangible improvements in Gaza, that would enable the UN and its partners to effectively implement a protection-centered ceasefire plan and deliver humanitarian assistance at the level required to address the acute needs of Palestinians.

As for the human rights situation in wake of the currently ongoing Iran crisis and its parties, there is a crucial need for the international community to address the occurring human rights abuses, as well as to call for respect for international humanitarian law on behalf of all relevant parties. Human Rights Watch found that Israeli forces unlawfully attacked Evin prison in Tehran

on June 23, 2025 absent any evident military target, killing and injuring scores of civilians in what it describes as an apparent war crime. The strikes were followed by ill-treatment and enforced disappearances of political prisoners at the hands of Iran's authorities. It also investigated five Iranian ballistic missile strikes that struck populated areas of Israel and killed 20 civilians and found that they were also likely war crimes, though that is not a judicial judgment. Further, a weapon hit an Iranian girls' primary school in Minab on 28 February 2026, reportedly killing over 165 children (UNESCO- UN News; Website: OHCHR-Press releases-Special Procedures) with The UN Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on the Islamic Republic of Iran (FFMI) stating that there are reasonable grounds to believe that the United States was responsible; according to Iran's Ministry of Cultural Heritage, US and/or Israeli attacks have also targeted cultural heritage sites. In response to these attacks, Iran has attacked both military and civilian infrastructure alike. In the end, it is civilians who bear the heaviest burden. The suffering is not confined to one side. Strikes have caused thousands of civilian casualties and displaced millions of people. Across the region, schools, medical facilities, residential buildings, and water and energy infrastructure have been destroyed or severely damaged. The broader context in which this crisis erupted is particularly alarming. The Iranian civilians had barely emerged from a violent crackdown when the bombs began to fall. According to Amnesty International, thousands were arbitrarily detained, interrogated, harassed and unjustly prosecuted for exercising their human rights. It also reports that more than 1.8 million Afghans were unlawfully expelled or forced to return to Afghanistan, and the highest number of executions since 1989 was recorded, among other things. Although the US has used the freedom of Iranian citizens as a justification for the conflict, it is nevertheless a catastrophe piling onto an already unbearable burden on communities in the region that have long endured repression, armed conflict, and the systematic denial of their rights. You will read more about the situation of human rights in both of these conflicts at a further point in this guide.

In the context of this specific agenda, it is very important that you are well researched. Considering the limited purview of the UNHRC, coupled with the continuously evolving nature of the conflicts, you must pay exceptional attention to your areas of focus. We cannot reiterate enough that this is not a disarmament committee or the security council and hence, does not have the power or scope to extensively discuss the technical elements of warfare. It is entirely possible that in pursuit of academic certainty and the aspiration to represent your State's interests, your arguments may overreach the ambit of this Council. That being said, we want to remind you that it is impermissible to discuss this agenda in terms of creating binding impositions of economic sanctions, deploying direct military interventions, enforcing nuclear non-proliferation agreements, etc. **Your core focus must remain on addressing the situation of human rights. The UNHRC is a recommendatory body, and strictly cannot make legally binding resolutions. Hence, any solutions or resolutions you may want to bring forth need to adhere to its mandate.**

International Humanitarian Law & International Human Rights Law

In the last few decades, governments, politicians, diplomats, activists, demonstrators and journalists have referred to international humanitarian law and human rights in armed conflicts. They are regularly referred to in United Nations Security Council resolutions, in United Nations Human Rights Council discussions, in political pamphlets of opposition movements, in reports of non-governmental organizations (NGOs), in the training of soldiers and in diplomatic discussions. International human rights law and international humanitarian law are now important parameters for many military commanders, advised on the ground by lawyers. They are often referred to by defence lawyers and prosecutors in international and—to a still limited extent—domestic tribunals, and form the basis for well-reasoned verdicts. International human rights law and international humanitarian law share the goal of preserving the dignity and humanity of all. Over the years, the General Assembly, the Commission on Human Rights and, more recently, the Human Rights Council have considered that, in armed conflict, parties to the conflict have legally binding obligations concerning the rights of persons affected by the conflict. Although different in scope, international human rights law and international humanitarian law offer a series of protections to persons in armed conflict, whether civilians, persons who are no longer participating directly in hostilities or active participants in the conflict. Indeed, as has been recognized, inter alia, by international and regional courts, as well as by United Nations organs, treaty bodies and human rights special procedures, both bodies of law apply to situations of armed conflict and provide complementary and mutually reinforcing protection.

International human rights law is a system of international norms designed to protect and promote the human rights of all persons. These rights, which are inherent in all human beings, whatever their nationality, place of residence, sex, national or ethnic origin, colour, religion, language, or any other status, are interrelated, interdependent and indivisible. They are often expressed and guaranteed by law, in the form of treaties, customary international law, and general principles. Human rights entail both rights and obligations. International human rights law lays down the obligations of States to act in certain ways or to refrain from certain acts, in order to promote and protect the human rights and fundamental freedoms of individuals or groups. International humanitarian law is a set of rules which seek, for humanitarian reasons, to limit the effects of armed conflict. It protects persons who are not or are no longer participating in the hostilities, and restricts the means and methods of warfare. Its scope is, therefore, limited ratione materiae to situations of armed conflict. International humanitarian law is part of jus in bello (the law on how force may be used), which has to be distinguished and separated from jus ad bellum (the law on the legitimacy of the use of force). The use of force is prohibited under the Charter of the United Nations. Nevertheless, international humanitarian law has to be applied equally by all sides to every armed conflict, regardless of whether their cause is justified.

For years, it was held that the difference between international human rights law and international humanitarian law was that the former applied in times of peace and the latter in situations of armed conflict. Modern international law, however, recognizes that this distinction is inaccurate. Indeed, it is widely recognized nowadays by the international community that since human rights obligations derive from the recognition of inherent rights of all human beings and that these rights could be affected both in times of peace and in times of war, international human rights law continues to apply in situations of armed conflict. Moreover, nothing in human rights treaties indicates that they would not be applicable in times of armed conflict. As a result, the two bodies of law—international human rights law and international humanitarian law—are considered to be complementary sources of obligations in situations of armed conflict. For example, the Human Rights Committee, in its general comments Nos. 29 (2001) and 31 (2004), recalled that the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights applied also in situations of armed conflict to which the rules of international humanitarian law were applicable. The Human Rights Council, in its resolution 9/9, further acknowledged that human rights law and international humanitarian law were complementary and mutually reinforcing. The Council considered that all human rights required protection equally and that the protection provided by human rights law continued in armed conflict, taking into account when international humanitarian law applied as lex specialis (Latin legal principle meaning that a specific law overrides a general law when both apply to the same situation). It also reiterated that effective measures to guarantee and monitor the implementation of human rights should be taken in respect of civilian populations in situations of armed conflict, including people under foreign occupation, and that effective protection against violations of their human rights should be provided, in accordance with international human rights law and applicable international humanitarian law.

As delegates of this committee, you will see the phrase “customary international law” used often during these discussions. Both treaty law and customary international law are sources of international law. Treaties, such as the four Geneva Conventions of 1949, are written conventions in which states formally establish certain rules. Treaties are binding only on those states that have expressed their consent to be bound by them, usually through ratification. Customary international law, on the other hand, derives from "a general practice accepted as law". Such practice can be found in official accounts of military operations but is also reflected in a variety of other official documents, including military manuals, national legislation and case law. The requirement that this practice be "accepted as law" is often referred to as opinio juris. This characteristic sets practices required by law apart from practices followed as a matter of policy, for example.

While international human rights law and international humanitarian law have different historical and doctrinal roots, both share the aim of protecting all persons and are grounded in the

principles of respect for the life, well-being and human dignity of the person.3 From a legal perspective, both international human rights law and international humanitarian law find their source in a series of international treaties, which have been reinforced and complemented by customary international law. Taking into account that international human rights law applies at all times—whether in peace or in war—and that international humanitarian law applies only in the context of armed conflicts, both bodies of law should be applied in a complementary and mutually reinforcing way in the context of armed conflict. Moreover, certain violations of international human rights and humanitarian law constitute crimes under international criminal law, so other bodies of law, such as the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, could, therefore, also be applicable. International criminal law and criminal justice on war crimes implement international humanitarian law, but they also clarify and develop its rules. Similarly, other bodies of law, such as international refugee law and domestic law, will often also be applicable and may influence the type of human rights protections available.

International human rights law is not limited to the rights enumerated in treaties, but also comprises rights and freedoms that have become part of customary international law, binding on all States, including those that are not party to a particular treaty. Many of the rights set out in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights are widely regarded to have this character. Furthermore, some rights are recognized as having a special status as peremptory norms of customary international law (jus cogens), which means that no derogation is admissible under any circumstance and that they prevail, in particular, over other international obligations. The prohibitions of torture, slavery, genocide, racial discrimination and crimes against humanity, and the right to self-determination are widely recognized as peremptory norms.

International humanitarian law finds its sources in treaties and in customary international law. The rules of international humanitarian law are set out in a series of conventions and protocols. The Hague Regulations are generally considered as corresponding to customary international law, binding on all States independently of their acceptance of them. The Geneva Conventions have attained universal ratification. Many of the provisions contained in the Geneva Conventions and their Protocols are considered to be part of customary international law and applicable in any armed conflict. Other international treaties dealing with the production, use and stockpiling of certain weapons are also considered part of international humanitarian law, insofar as they regulate the conduct of armed hostilities and impose limitations on the use of certain weapons. Additionally, The International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) has a special role under international humanitarian law. The Geneva Conventions stipulate that it will visit prisoners, organize relief operations, contribute to family reunification and conduct a range of humanitarian activities during international armed conflicts

Principles of Proportionality, Distinction and Precautions:

Since the adoption of the Geneva Conventions, in 1949, IHL has restricted the means and methods of warfare in all situations of armed conflict, regardless of the just cause or just war claimed by the belligerents. Under IHL, the protection of civilians in armed conflict is governed by three fundamental principles: distinction, proportionality and precaution.

Applying the principle of proportionality is critically important for protecting civilians and critical infrastructure in situations of armed conflict. The principle of proportionality is codified in Article 51(5)(b) of the 1977 Additional Protocol I, which reflects customary international law. It prohibits attacks 'which may be expected to cause incidental loss of civilian life, injury to civilians, damage to civilian objects, or a combination thereof, which would be excessive in relation to the concrete and direct military advantage anticipated'. The principle of proportionality is a corollary of the principle of distinction and it recognizes that, in the conduct of hostilities, causing incidental harm to civilians and civilian objects is often unavoidable. However, it places a limit on the extent of incidental civilian harm that is permissible whenever military objectives are attacked, by spelling out how the principles of humanity and necessity must be balanced in such situations. The principle of proportionality is further reinforced by certain rules flowing from the principle of precautions in attack, in particular the obligation to do everything feasible to assess whether an attack may be expected to be disproportionate and to cancel or suspend an attack if it becomes apparent that it may be expected to have disproportionate effects. Overall, an attack against a military objective can be lawful only if the principles of proportionality and precautions are respected, meaning that the incidental civilian harm must not be excessive, and the attacker must have taken all feasible precautions to avoid this harm or at least reduce it.

Proportionality is particularly important in densely populated areas, where the distinction between military targets and civilians is complex and the potential for civilian collateral damage is high. It also plays a key role in the legality of attack of targets that have a civilian and military dual use. It must be recalled that the proportionality requirement is not satisfied by warning civilians to leave the area of military operations. Indeed, effective advance warning is provided by IHL as a separate and additional precaution to be taken when an attack may affect the civilian population. However, it cannot replace the other precautionary and proportionality requirements imposed by IHL for the protection of civilians in the conduct of hostilities.

The principle of distinction is also one of the cardinal principles of international humanitarian law. The principle is now codified in article 48, 51(2), 52(2) of the 1977 Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions. The principle is most prominent in article 48. The article states that parties to the conflict "shall at all times distinguish between the civilian population and combatants and between civilian objects and military objectives and accordingly shall direct their

operations only against military objectives", in order to "ensure respect for and protection of the civilian population and civilian objects".

Furthermore, the principle of distinction is a fundamental aspect of customary international humanitarian law. Even in the absence of explicit treaty obligations, the principle of distinction has become a customary norm binding on all armed conflict parties, whether they have ratified specific treaties addressing the matter.

In IHL, civilian objects are defined as all objects that are not military objectives. Military objectives are limited to 'objects which by their nature, location, purpose or use make an effective contribution to military action and whose partial or total destruction, capture or neutralization, in the circumstances ruling at the time, offers a definite military advantage'. This means that civilian infrastructure (including water and electricity plants, private property, or civilian government equipment and infrastructure) or any other civilian object must not be attacked, though there can be exceptions in certain cases. In non-international armed conflict (NIAC), all persons who are not members of state armed forces or organised armed groups of a party to the conflict are civilians. Therefore, they are entitled to protection against direct attack unless and for such time as they take a direct part in hostilities. In non-international armed conflict, organised armed groups constitute the armed forces of a non-state party to the conflict and consist only of individuals whose continuous function is to take a direct part in hostilities ('continuous combat function').

Another central notion under international humanitarian law is the principle of precautions in attack: parties to a conflict must take steps to minimise civilian harm. During hostilities the parties to an armed conflict are obliged to respect the rule on precautions in attack. Rules relating to precaution are intended to guarantee that the parties will never disregard the presence of civilians and are obligated to take steps to minimise the harm caused to civilians. The obligation to take precautionary measures to protect civilians is placed on both the attacker and the defender. For instance, the attacker needs to take the presence of civilians prior to any attack into account and make adjustments to its strategy as necessary and feasible. The leadership of the attacked community, on the other hand, needs to take feasible steps to minimise the anticipated harm towards its own civilian population, most notably by not situating military objects close to civilian objects. These general principles are rooted in the following legal provisions, which state that whenever civilians are present, parties to an armed conflict must both take precautions during military operations to spare the civilian population and civilian objects (Article 57 of Additional Protocol One), and take precautions to protect the civilian population and civilian objects under their own control against the effects of military attacks (Article 58 Additional Protocol One).

The principle of precautions in attack was first set out in Article 2(3) of the 1907 Hague Convention (IX). It is now more clearly codified in Article 57(1) of Additional Protocol I, to

which no reservations have been made, and Rule 15 of the ICRC study on customary international law. The obligation to take constant care and to take precautions to avoid or minimize incidental civilian losses is also contained in numerous military manuals.

Definitions

The Executive Board is aware of the ambiguity and discourse surrounding some of the terms in this guide. Therefore, for uniformity, we request that you accept the following as the definitions of these terms for the purpose of this background guide:

Occupied territory: Under international humanitarian law (IHL), there is occupation when a state exercises an unconsented-to effective control over a territory to which it has no sovereign title. The definition commonly used nowadays is the one contained in the Regulations Concerning the Laws and Customs of War on Land annexed to the Fourth Hague Convention of 18 August 1907 (H.IV). Section III of the regulations details the rights and obligations of the military authority over enemy territory. Article 42 of The Hague Regulations of 1907 defines occupation as follows: "Territory is considered occupied when it is actually placed under the authority of the hostile army. The occupation extends only to the territory where such authority has been established and can be exercised." These are very old regulations that, according to the International Court of Justice, have acquired the status of international customary law.
Occupation law – as a branch of IHL – regulates the partial or total occupation of a territory by a hostile army. Provisions regulating occupation can be found in The Hague Regulations of 1907, the Fourth Geneva Convention and Protocol I additional to the Geneva Conventions. Under occupation law, the occupying power does not acquire sovereignty over the occupied territory and is required to respect the existing laws and institutions of the occupied territory as far as possible. It is presumed that occupation will be temporary and that the occupying power shall preserve the status quo ante in the occupied territory.

Occupied Palestinian Territory: The Occupied Palestinian Territory (OPT) is a term that refers to the West Bank, including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip. These territories have been militarily occupied by Israel since the 1967 Arab-Israeli War. Amongst other bodies and international organisations, the United Nations (UN), European Union (EU) and International Court of Justice (ICJ) have all come to use this designation. Following the granting of observer status to the State of Palestine in the United Nations in 2012 by the adoption of resolution 67/19 by the United Nations General Assembly on 29 November 2012, it was agreed by the UN that the term ‘OPT’ may be used to refer to the West Bank, including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip, in order to make clear its continuing designation and status as occupied.

Axis of Resistance: It is a loose and informal military network of militant groups in the Middle East that are supported by Iran and its Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and bill themselves as resistance forces. By 2025 the network appeared to be diminished as the Israel-Hamas conflict, Israel-Hezbollah conflict, and Israel-Iran conflict exhausted several of the principal actors. Each group in the network acts independently of one another and is motivated by its own self-interest, but the network coordinates in training, attaining weaponry, and supporting one another in achieving common goals. In addition to the IRGC, the axis comprises:

a) Hezbollah in Lebanon
b) Hamas and the Palestinian Islamic Jihad (PIJ) in the Gaza Strip and the West Bank
c) Houthi forces in Yemen
d) Certain militias in Iraq called the Islamic Resistance in Iraq (IRI), which includes militias within the Popular Mobilization Forces (PMF) coalition

Crimes Against Humanity (Source: 1998 Article 7, Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court): crimes against humanity are defined as "any of the following acts when committed as part of a widespread or systematic attack directed against any civilian population." The acts include murder, extermination, enslavement, deportation, imprisonment, torture, rape (and other gender-based or sex crimes), group-based persecution, enforced disappearance, apartheid, and "other inhumane acts of a similar character intentionally causing great suffering or serious injury to body or to mental or physical health." Under Article 7 of the Rome Statute, the context of a widespread or systematic attack against a civilian population matters, and the accused must have knowledge of the attack. For the sake of ease of understanding, this definition isn't inclusive of the intricate contextual and legal elements of the crime. It is notable that a serious human rights violation does not automatically constitute a crime against humanity.

Collective punishment: The prohibition of collective punishment in IHL dates back to Hague Convention (II) of 1899. Art. 50 of the annexed Hague Regulations provides that "[n]o general penalty, pecuniary or otherwise, can be inflicted upon the population on account of the acts of individuals for which they cannot be regarded as jointly and severally responsible." Art. 33(1) of the Fourth Geneva Convention (GC IV), adopted unanimously by states, contains a similar but more specific prohibition, providing that "[n]o protected person may be punished for an offence he or she has not personally committed. Collective penalties and likewise all measures of intimidation or of terrorism are prohibited." Common article 3 to the Geneva Conventions prohibits in all circumstances acts including murder, mutilation, cruel, humiliating and degrading treatment, and torture against civilians and other persons no longer taking part in the hostilities. Article 4 of Protocol II also sets out the fundamental guarantees of humane treatment, which explicitly includes a prohibition on collective punishments, acts of terrorism, and pillage.
Aid personnel: Humanitarian aid workers assist people in need due to conflicts, natural disasters, outbreaks, a breakdown of health care or infrastructure, and more. Assistance may begin within hours after a disaster and often may continue for years. Humanitarian relief deployments can last

for weeks to years. Many of these efforts are coordinated by the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, which estimated that approximately 363 million people needed humanitarian assistance in 2023 (Global Humanitarian Overview 2023, July Update) , representing continual rapid growth over the prior decade. Professional aid workers often deploy with large specialist organizations (e.g., Doctors Without Borders) that have infrastructure and resources to properly support their personnel.

Genocide: The UN draws its definition of genocide from the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, which was approved by General Assembly Resolution 260 A (III) of 9 December 1948, and entered into force on 12 January 1951. The same definition was also included in the 1998 Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court (ICC), making genocide one of the international crimes over which the ICC has jurisdiction. Clearly, the reach of this Convention goes far. According to Article II of the Convention, genocide means any of the following acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group, as such:
(a) Killing members of the group;
(b) Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group;
(c) Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part;
(d) Imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group;
(e) Forcibly transferring children of the group to another group.

Historical Context:

The history behind these issues is complex and heavily controversial. This section aims to give you a mere gist of the situation and cannot completely capture the nuances of these issues with the appropriate care and focus they deserve. This is not because we do not wish to do so, but rather due to the constraints regarding time and length so as to not detract from the other sections of this guide. We hope you use this to research further as it is not a comprehensive account of the intricate history behind these regions.

The question of Palestine is one that is being debated throughout nearly a century. It is not possible to condense it into just a few paragraphs without simplifying the social, cultural, legal and religious debate surrounding it. Hence, we have adapted much of the text in this section from the official United Nations website. Palestine was among former Ottoman territories placed under UK administration by the League of Nations in 1922. All of these territories eventually became fully independent States, except Palestine, where in addition to “the rendering of administrative assistance and advice” the British Mandate incorporated the “Balfour

Declaration" of 1917, expressing support for "the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people". During the Mandate, from 1922 to 1947, large-scale Jewish immigration, mainly from Eastern Europe took place, the numbers swelling in the 1930s with the Nazi persecution. Arab demands for independence and resistance to immigration led to a rebellion in 1937, followed by continuing terrorism and violence from both sides. The UK considered various formulas to bring independence to a land ravaged by violence. In 1947, the UK turned the Palestine problem over to the UN. After looking at alternatives, the UN proposed terminating the Mandate and partitioning Palestine into two independent States, one Palestinian Arab and the other Jewish, with Jerusalem internationalized (Resolution 181 (II) of 1947). One of the two envisaged States proclaimed its independence as Israel and in the 1948 war involving neighbouring Arab States expanded to 77 percent of the territory of Mandate Palestine, including the larger part of Jerusalem. Over half of the Palestinian Arab population fled or were expelled. Jordan and Egypt controlled the rest of the territory assigned by resolution 181 to the Arab State. In the 1967 war, Israel occupied these territories (Gaza Strip and the West Bank) including East Jerusalem, which was subsequently annexed by Israel. The war brought about a second exodus of Palestinians, estimated at half a million. Security Council Resolution 242 (1967) formulated the principles of a just and lasting peace, including an Israeli withdrawal from territories occupied in the conflict, a just settlement of the refugee problem, and the termination of all claims or states of belligerency. The 1973 hostilities were followed by Security Council Resolution 338, which inter alia called for peace negotiations between the parties concerned. In 1974 the General Assembly reaffirmed the inalienable rights of the Palestinian people to self-determination, national independence, sovereignty, and to return. The following year, the General Assembly established the Committee on the Exercise of the Inalienable Rights of the Palestinian People and conferred on the PLO the status of observer in the Assembly and in UN conferences.

In June 1982, Israel invaded Lebanon with the declared intention to eliminate the PLO. A cease-fire was arranged. PLO troops withdrew from Beirut and were transferred to neighboring countries. Despite the guarantees of safety for Palestine refugees left behind, a large-scale massacre took place in the Sabra and Shatila camps. In September 1983, the International Conference on the Question of Palestine (ICQP) adopted the following principles: the need to oppose Israeli settlements and Israeli actions to change the status of Jerusalem, the right of all States in the region to existence within secure and internationally recognized boundaries, and the attainment of the legitimate, inalienable rights of the Palestinian people. In 1987, a mass uprising against the Israeli occupation began in the Occupied Palestinian Territory (the intifada). Methods used by the Israeli forces resulted in mass injuries and heavy loss of life among the civilian Palestinian population. In 1988 the Palestine National Council meeting in Algiers proclaimed the establishment of the State of Palestine. A Peace Conference was convened in Madrid in 1991, with the aim of achieving a peaceful settlement through direct negotiations along 2 tracks: between Israel and the Arab States, and between Israel and the Palestinians, based on Security

Council resolutions 242 (1967) and 338 (1973). The multilateral track negotiations were to focus on region-wide issues such as the environment, arms control, refugees, water, and the economy. A series of subsequent negotiations culminated in the mutual recognition between the Government of Israel and the PLO, the representative of the Palestinian people, and the signing in 1993 of the Declaration of Principles on Interim Self-Government Arrangements (DOP or "Oslo Accord"), as well as the subsequent implementation agreements, which led to the partial withdrawal of Israeli forces, the elections to the Palestinian Council and the Presidency of the Palestinian Authority, the partial release of prisoners and the establishment of a functioning administration in the areas under Palestinian self-rule. The involvement of the UN has been essential both as the guardian of international legitimacy and in the mobilization and provision of international assistance. The 1993 DOP deferred certain issues to subsequent permanent status negotiations, which were held in 2000 at Camp David and in 2001 in Taba, but proved inconclusive. The visit by Ariel Sharon of the Likud to Al-Haram Al-Sharif (Temple Mount) in Jerusalem in 2000 was followed by the second intifada. Israel began the construction of a West Bank separation wall, located mostly within the Occupied Palestinian Territory, ruled illegal by the International Court of Justice. In 2002, the Security Council affirmed a vision of two States, Israel and Palestine. In 2002 the Arab League adopted the Arab Peace Initiative. The Quartet, composed of the European Union, Russia, United Nations, and United States was established in 2002 to facilitate the Middle-East Peace Process negotiations. The Quartet was welcomed in United Nations Security Council resolution 1397 (2002) following the Second Intifada. In 2003, the Quartet released a Road Map to a two-State solution. An unofficial Geneva peace accord was promulgated by prominent Israelis and Palestinians in 2003. In 2005, Israel withdrew its settlers and troops from Gaza while retaining control over its borders, seashore and airspace. Following Palestinian legislative elections of 2006, the Quartet conditioned assistance to the PA on its commitment to nonviolence, recognition of Israel, and acceptance of previous agreements. After an armed takeover of Gaza by Hamas in 2007, Israel imposed a blockade. The Annapolis process of 2007-2008 failed to yield a permanent status agreement. Escalating rocket fire and air strikes in late 2008 culminated in Israeli ground operation "Cast Lead" in Gaza. The UN Security Council adopted resolution 1860. Violations of international law during the Gaza conflict were investigated by the UN (Goldstone Report).

The 2009 PA programme to build State institutions received wide international support. A new round of negotiations in 2010 broke down following the expiration of the Israeli settlement moratorium. In 2011 President Mahmoud Abbas submitted the application of Palestine for membership in the UN. UNESCO admitted Palestine as a Member. Exploratory Israeli-Palestinian talks were held in early 2012 in Amman. In November another cycle of violence between Israel and Gaza concluded with an Egyptian-brokered cease-fire. On 29 November 2012 Palestine was granted non-member observer State status in the UN. The General Assembly proclaimed 2014 an International Year of Solidarity with the Palestinian People. A new round of negotiations begun in 2013 was suspended by Israel in April 2014 following the

announcement of a Palestinian national consensus Government. Another round of fighting between Israel and Gaza took place in July-August 2014. In 2016 the Security Council adopted resolution 2334 on settlements. In 2017, the US Administration announced recognition of Jerusalem as the capital of Israel, and subsequently, the US and certain other embassies were moved to Jerusalem. In 2020, the US mediated agreements to normalize relations between Israel and the UAE, Bahrain, Sudan, and Morocco ("Abraham Accords"). In May 2023 the UN commemorated the Nakba anniversary. In October, a major escalation between Gaza and Israel began. South Africa filed an ICJ case against Israel alleging genocide. While the case progressed, the Court ordered Israel to prevent genocide, enable provision of basic services and aid in Gaza, and curb incitement to genocide. In May 2024 State of Palestine was granted additional rights and privileges at the UN. In July the International Court of Justice found Israel's presence in the OPT unlawful: Israel should bring it to an end as rapidly as possible, cease settlement activities, evacuate settlers, and make reparations. In September the General Assembly demanded that Israel end its occupation in 12 months. In January 2025 a Gaza ceasefire came into effect. However, the pause was short lived as Israel launched airstrikes on Gaza on 18 March, effectively ending the ceasefire. From 28 to 30 July 2025, a High-Level International Conference took place in the UN Headquarters which adopted a final outcome document entitled "New York Declaration on the Peaceful Settlement of the Question of Palestine and Implementation of the Two-State Solution" (A/CONF.243/2025/1). On 12 September, the General Assembly adopted a resolution by 142 votes in favor to 10 against (12 abstained) endorsing the "New York Declaration." On 22 September 2025, the resumed Conference concluded with groundbreaking momentum as Heads of State and Government and other senior officials from 10 countries (Andorra, Australia, Belgium, Canada, France, Luxembourg, Malta, Monaco, Portugal and the United Kingdom) announced their recognition of an independent State of Palestine. On 22 August 2025, the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) Famine Review Committee confirmed in a new analysis that Famine (IPC Phase 5) was occurring in Gaza Governorate. On 16 September, the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem, and Israel issued a new report stating that "Israel has committed genocide against Palestinians in the Gaza Strip".

The history behind the conflict involving Iran is also a delicate issue of immense importance. The ongoing crisis is heavily influenced by tensions that have been in existence for a long period of time, such as Iran's nuclear program. Iran has pursued a nuclear program since at least 1957, with periods of significant interruption. Spurred by security concerns from its war with Iraq, Iran is believed to have decided to pursue nuclear weapons as early as the mid-1980s. Throughout the 1990s, Iran pursued agreements with China and Russia to advance the program. In the summer of 2002, the National Council of Resistance of Iran, an umbrella organization made up of Iranian dissident groups, exposed the existence of two Iranian nuclear sites that were hidden from the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). By 2003, diplomats launched an intensive effort to

halt Iran's nuclear program. Iran agreed, insisting only on keeping its centrifuges for nuclear energy. However, it did not follow through on its commitment to transparent reporting by failing to declare nuclear materials and activities identified by the IAEA, leading to a June 2004 rebuke and a September 2005 finding of non-compliance by the IAEA, paving the way for a future referral to the UN Security Council (UNSC). In 2006, the UNSC adopted Resolution 1696, the first legally binding call for Iran to suspend its uranium enrichment program. Over the next few years, the UNSC adopted a series of resolutions imposing economic sanctions on Iran for its failure to suspend its enrichment-related activities. Over the next two years, the United States convened several rounds of bilateral talks and led the other P5+1 coalition members—China, France, Germany, Russia, and the United Kingdom—in negotiations with Iran's new leadership. These efforts culminated in the adoption of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) in 2015. Once key parties signed the agreement, the UNSC approved UN Resolution 2231, paving the way for sanctions relief. Although the JCPOA limited Iran's nuclear ambitions, its regional ambitions continued to grow. Iran persisted in arming and training Shiite militants through its Quds Force—the international arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC)—which has exacerbated sectarian divisions in the Middle East. Iran has provided years of military aid and training to the Palestinian militant group Hamas. The Quds Force has also provided advanced armed drones to Hezbollah in Lebanon, trained and funded more than one hundred thousand Shiite fighters in Syria, supplied ballistic missiles and drones to Yemen's Houthis, and helped Shiite militias in Iraq build missile capabilities.

Because the JCPOA only addressed Iran's nuclear program, and not its revisionism or ballistic missile programs, the first Trump administration withdrew the United States from the agreement in 2018 and reimposed sanctions, pledging to seek a more comprehensive deal. The sanctions triggered the worst economic crisis Iran had faced in forty years, cutting oil exports by more than half. As the Trump administration pursued a maximum pressure strategy to bring Iran back to the negotiating table, Iran began contravening the JCPOA's nuclear restrictions. Tensions escalated through mid-2019: the United States designated the IRGC a terrorist organization, deployed additional forces to the region, and blamed Iran for attacks on six oil tankers near the Strait of Hormuz. In June, Iran downed a U.S. Global Hawk drone, prompting a U.S. cyberattack and new sanctions. Tensions peaked in early 2020 when the United States killed Quds Force commander Qasem Soleimani in a Baghdad air strike. Iran responded by progressively ceasing to observe specified nuclear restrictions, and while on high alert, accidentally shot down a Ukrainian passenger plane. Throughout the end of 2020, Trump continued imposing sanctions, while Iran further boosted uranium enrichment to levels after the assassination of a top nuclear scientist.

The October 2023 Hamas attack on Israel and subsequent war in Gaza triggered a regionwide escalation. In the months that followed, Iran-backed forces launched more than 170 attacks on U.S. and coalition forces in Iraq and Syria, prompting U.S. air strikes on two Iran-backed facilities in Syria in October 2023 and strikes on more than 85 targets across seven facilities in

Iraq and Syria in February 2024. The Houthis in Yemen and Hezbollah in Lebanon—both part of Iran's axis of resistance—simultaneously launched attacks from the Red Sea and Israel's northern border with Lebanon, raising the prospect of a broader regional war. In 2024, the Israel-Iran confrontation shifted from proxy-based hostilities to direct exchanges of fire. In April, an Israeli air strike on an Iranian consulate annex in Damascus killed two Iranian generals, prompting Iran to launch over three hundred drones and missiles at Israel—its first direct strike on Israeli territory. In October 2024, following the killing of Hezbollah leader Hassan Nasrallah in September, Iran launched approximately 180 ballistic missiles against Israel on October 1. Later that month, Israel killed Hamas leader Yahya Sinwar, further escalating regional tensions. Israel responded with a large-scale retaliatory strike on Iran, targeting air defenses and missile production facilities. Coupled with the downfall of the Assad regime in Syria, the losses significantly degraded the axis of resistance. Upon returning to office in 2025, U.S. President Donald Trump restored his maximum pressure campaign against Tehran while initiating new rounds of US-Iran nuclear talks. Israel, opposed to the negotiations, launched a unilateral military strike against Iran on June 13—one day after the IAEA Board of Governors found Iran in non-compliance with its obligations under its Safeguards Agreement—targeting nuclear facilities, missile factories, senior military officials, and nuclear scientists. Iran declared the attack an act of war and retaliated by launching waves of drones and dozens of ballistic missiles. Despite having recently resumed nuclear negotiations, Trump voiced increasing support for Israel's objectives and signaled openness to regime change in Tehran.

After a week of Israeli-Iranian exchanges, the United States directly intervened on June 22, striking Iranian nuclear sites in Fordow, Isfahan, and Natanz. Although the Trump administration claimed that the strikes had significantly hindered Iran's nuclear programme, a preliminary US Defense Intelligence Agency assessment reportedly suggested that the damage may have delayed the programme by only a matter of months. Iran retaliated against U.S. forces stationed at the Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar on June 23; Trump announced a ceasefire later that day. Meanwhile, widespread economic hardship and the collapse of Iran's rial currency sparked massive anti-government protests in late December 2025. As unrest spread, the regime imposed a nationwide internet blackout, obscuring extreme violence against protestors. Estimates suggest the government's crackdown killed over six thousand protesters, with more than seventeen thousand additional death reports under investigation. Trump initially threatened military intervention if Iranian protesters were killed, but later backed away from immediate strike plans. Even as the United States conducted the largest military buildup in the Middle East since the 2003 invasion of Iraq, it continued nuclear talks with Iran.

When Tehran would not accede to U.S. demands to end all nuclear enrichment activity, the United States and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, 2026. Trump stated the war goals were to destroy Iran's ballistic missile capabilities, eliminate its navy, prevent Iran from ever acquiring a nuclear weapon, and sever its support for proxy forces. Trump also called for regime change,

encouraging Iranians to seize control of their government. Large-scale strikes targeted Iranian military assets and the Islamic Republic's top leadership, killing Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Tehran's Assembly of Experts appointed Ali Khamenei's son, Mojtaba Khamenei, to succeed him. Iran retaliated by launching missile and drone strikes against U.S. military facilities in Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates, as well as against Israel and Gulf states' energy and civilian infrastructure, including airports and oil facilities. Israel, in turn, launched a military offensive into southern Lebanon, displacing hundreds of thousands of people, after Hezbollah fired rockets at Israeli territory for the first time in over a year. The attack quickly escalated into a regional war with widespread ramifications for critical supply chains and humanitarian aid. Iran's effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz—one of the world's most significant oil and natural gas chokepoints—has caused a global energy shock. The United States responded by imposing a naval blockade of Iranian ports.

Although complete casualty figures do not exist, the Human Rights Activists News Agency (HRANA) has documented 1,701 civilian deaths in Iran. The Shajareh Tayyebeh girls' primary school in Minab, Iran, was struck during the opening US-Israeli military operations against Iran. UN experts reported at least 165 schoolgirls killed and called for an independent investigation, and up to 3.2 million have also been displaced. Thirteen U.S. service members have been killed. The United States and Iran reached a two-week ceasefire on April 7, but continued to intermittently trade strikes. On June 14, the United States and Iran agreed to an interim deal mediated by Pakistan that included reopening the Strait of Hormuz, an end to fighting between Hezbollah and Israel in Lebanon, and a cessation of hostilities for sixty days. Both sides have accused each other of violating the agreement's terms, and the prospect of a comprehensive settlement remains uncertain. Iran has continued to attack merchant ships in the Strait of Hormuz, and the United States accuses it of delaying follow-on discussions regarding the future of its nuclear program, whereas Iran blames the United States for failing to ensure a ceasefire and Israeli withdrawal in Lebanon.

Timeline of Events

(Source: The United Nations website, The Question of Palestine- Timeline of Events)

1890-92: The term "Zionism" first coined by the Viennese writer, Nathan Birnbaum.

1896: Theodor Herzl, founder of the Zionist movement, calls for "restoration of the Jewish State".

1897: First Zionist congress takes place in Basel, Switzerland and the first Zionist organization is founded.

1907: Zionist leader Chaim Weizmann visits Palestine.

1908: First Palestinian anti-Zionist weekly newspaper is published by Arab Christian Najib Nassar.

1915: British cabinet member Herbert Samuel calls for the British annexation of Palestine in memorandum “The Future of Palestine”.

1916: European Powers conclude secret Sykes-Picot agreement dividing future spheres of influence in Ottoman Empire territories.

1917: The Balfour Declaration promises a “national home for the Jewish people in Palestine”.

1919: Emir Feisal presents a memorandum to the Paris Peace Conference, outlining the case for independence of Arab countries.

1922: The League of Nations grants mandate over former Ottoman territory Palestine to UK. Provisions include terms of the Balfour Declaration, including a “Jewish national home”.

1933: Palestinians riot amid sudden rise in Jewish immigration from Nazi persecution in Germany.

1936-1939: Palestinian rebellion against the British Mandate and Jewish immigration.

1937: UK Peel Commission Report publicly recognizes conflict’s irreconcilable terms and recommends partition of Palestine.

1939: UK issues White Paper limiting Jewish immigration.

1942: US Zionists meet in NY and adopt the “Biltmore Programme“, calling for establishment of Palestine as a Jewish Commonwealth and for unlimited immigration.

1947: In February, UK proposes to relinquish its mandatory role and places the question of Palestine before the UN.

In September, the UN Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP) issues a report to the General Assembly with plans for partition or a federal state in Palestine.

In November, the UN General Assembly adopts resolution 181(II) which called to divide Palestine into an un-named “Jewish State” and an un-named “Arab State” with Jerusalem under UN trusteeship.

APRIL 1948: Deir Yassin massacre: Zionist paramilitary groups kill hundreds of Palestinian Arabs in Deir Yassin, a village near Jerusalem.

MAY 1948: Great Britain terminates the Mandate over Palestine and Israel declares independence on 14 May 1948, while the British Mandate ends at midnight, 15 May. First large-scale displacement of Palestine refugees; 15 May becomes an official day to mark the Palestinian Nakba (“catastrophe”).

The first Arab-Israeli War broke out when five Arab nations – Egypt, Transjordan (Jordan), Iraq, Syria, and Lebanon – invaded firstly the areas in southern and eastern Palestine not apportioned to the Jewish State by the UN partition of Palestine, and later, East Jerusalem.

Count Folke Bernadotte appointed UN Mediator in Palestine by the UN General Assembly. He is assassinated four months later by a Zionist militant group.

The Security Council establishes a group of military observers to supervise the truce, which later became UNTSO.

NOVEMBER 1948: UN establishes special fund to provide relief to over 500,000 Palestine refugees.

DECEMBER 1948: UN General Assembly passes resolution 194 calling for refugees to be allowed to return, Jerusalem to be under international regime, UN Conciliation Commission for Palestine (UNCCP) replaces UN mediator.

FEBRUARY-JULY 1949: Israel signs armistice agreements with Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon and Syria.

APRIL 1949: UN Conciliation Commission convenes Lausanne Conference to reconcile the parties.

MAY 1949: UNGA adopts Resolution 273 (III) admitting Israel as UN member.

DECEMBER 1949: UN establishes UNRWA to replace UNRPR (GA Resolution 302 (IV)).

1950: Israel moves its capital from Tel Aviv to the western part of Jerusalem, in defiance of UN resolutions, and the West Bank is brought formally under Jordanian control.

1964: Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) is founded in Cairo.

1967: Six-day war: Israel occupies West Bank, including East Jerusalem, Gaza, Golan Heights, and Sinai Peninsula.

In November, the UN Security Council unanimously adopts Resolution 242 (Land for peace).

1968: Establishment of UN Special Committee to Investigate Israeli Practices Affecting the Human Rights of the Palestinian People and Other Arabs of the Occupied Territories.

1973: Following the Middle East war of October, the UN Security Council passes resolution 338 calling for ceasefire, implementation of res. 242, negotiations between parties.

1974: The UN General Assembly and the Arab League recognize the PLO as the sole legitimate representative of the Palestinian people.

General Assembly reaffirms inalienable rights of Palestinian people to self-determination, independence and sovereignty, and refugee return (resolution 3236).

1975: In 1975 the Committee on the Exercise of the Inalienable Rights of the Palestinian People (CEIRPP) is founded by Resolution 3376 of the UNGA.

1976: The CEIRPP submits its programme to the Security Council and General Assembly to enable Palestinians to exercise their inalienable rights.

1977: Pursuant to UNGA Resolution 32/40 B, International Day of Solidarity with the Palestinian People is celebrated annually on 29 November.

1978: Following two weeks of secret negotiations at Camp David (USA), the Egyptian President and the Israeli Prime Minister agree on a Framework for Peace in the Middle East.

1979: The UNGA re-designates the Special Unit on Palestinian Rights as the Division for Palestinian Rights (Resolution 34/65 D).

1980: Israeli Knesset enacts the so-called ‘Basic Law’ on Jerusalem, proclaiming that “Jerusalem, whole and united” is the capital of Israel; the Security Council and GA resolution 35/169 E censure this law.

1981: UNESCO adds the Old City of Jerusalem to the UNESCO World Heritage Site list.

UN Security Council adopts resolution 497, calling on Israel to rescind action to annex the Golan Heights.

1982: Israel invades Lebanon with the intention of eliminating the PLO. After a ceasefire, PLO forces withdraw to neighboring countries. Despite guarantees of safety for Palestine refugees left behind, there are massacres at Sabra and Shatila camps.

1987: First "Intifada" begins in the Jabaliya Refugee Camp in the Gaza Strip.

1988: In July, Jordan renounces claims to the West Bank and recognizes PLO as "the sole legitimate representative of the Palestinian people."

In November, in Algiers, the Palestinian National Council adopts declaration of independence of the State of Palestine.

In December, PLO Chair Yasser Arafat addresses UN in Geneva; says Palestine National Council accepts UNSC Resolutions 242 and 338.

1991: Middle East peace conference in Madrid brings together all the parties to the Arab-Israeli conflict.

1993: Israel and the PLO sign the Declaration of Principles on Interim Self-Government Arrangements, also known as the Oslo Accords. Several "permanent status" issues are deferred for future negotiations.

1994: The Office of the UN Special Coordinator in the Occupied Territories (UNSCO) is established, and Mr. Terje Roed-Larsen of Norway is appointed as the first UN Special Coordinator.

1995: Israel and the PLO sign the Palestinian-Israeli Interim Agreement on the West Bank and the Gaza Strip ("Oslo II").

1996: Palestinian general elections are held.

1997: Israel and the PLO sign the Hebron Protocol.

1998: Israel and the PLO sign the Wye River Memorandum, which consists of steps to facilitate implementation of previous agreements.

2000: In July, the US President Clinton convenes a Middle East Peace Summit at Camp David which concludes without agreement.

Ariel Sharon's al-Haram al-Sharif visit in September 2000 triggers the Second Palestinian Intifada.

2001: Outgoing US President Clinton proposes the Clinton Parameters for a permanent status agreement to resolve the Israeli–Palestinian conflict.

Shortly afterwards, the Taba Summit is held between Israel and the Palestinian Authority but fails to resolve the "permanent status" issues.

2002: The UN Security Council passes resolution 1397 affirming vision of a two-State solution to the conflict. The Quartet, consisting of the UN, the EU, the US, and Russia is established with a mandate to help mediate Israeli-Palestinian conflict and support Palestinian economic development and institution-building.

During a summit in Beirut, the League of Arab States adopts the Arab Peace Initiative.

2003: Roadmap for Peace is published by the Quartet and is endorsed by the Security Council in resolution 1515.

2004: The International Court of Justice (ICJ) issues Advisory Opinion on the legality of construction of a wall in the Occupied Palestinian Territory.

2006: In January, Hamas wins Palestinian Legislative Elections; forms Palestinian Authority government. The Quartet responds with Quartet Principles.

In July, Israel goes to war with Hezbollah in Lebanon.

2007: Israel imposes a blockade on the Gaza Strip after an armed takeover of Gaza by Hamas.

In November, the Annapolis Conference ends with parties issuing a joint statement committing to immediately implement their respective obligations under the Roadmap and working towards a peace treaty by the end of 2008.

2008: Israel broadens its sanctions and completely seals off the Gaza Strip.

Later in the year, Israel launches "Operation Cast Lead", a 22-day military assault on the Gaza Strip.

2009: Security Council passes resolution 1860 calling for a ceasefire in Gaza. HRC creates the UN Fact Finding Mission on the Gaza conflict to investigate violations of international humanitarian and human rights law. Their findings are issued in the "Goldstone Report".

2012: In November, Israel launches 'Pillar of Defense' , an 8-day military operation against the Gaza Strip.

Later that month, the General Assembly adopts resolution 67/19 granting Palestine the status of non-member observer State in the UN.

2013: Direct negotiations between Israel and Palestine are held following an initiative by US Secretary of State John Kerry to restart the peace process.

2014: Israel launches a large-scale military operation codenamed "Protective Edge" on the Gaza Strip.

2016: UN Security Council adopts resolution 2334, stating that Israel's settlement activity constitutes a "flagrant violation" of international law and has "no legal validity".

2017: US President Trump announces that the United States would recognize Jerusalem as the capital of Israel.

2018: US embassy in Israel moved from Tel Aviv to Jerusalem.

2020: US President Trump helps mediate Abraham Accords to normalize Israel's relations with some Arab States and proposes a Peace Plan.

2022: General Assembly adopts resolution A/RES/77/23 requesting the Committee to Commemorate the Nakba for the first time in the history of the UN.

2023: Israel launches "Operation Swords of Iron" against Gaza following Hamas attack. South Africa initiates a genocide case against Israel at the ICJ.

2024: The ICJ's 19 July 2024 advisory opinion concluded that Israel's continued presence in the Occupied Palestinian Territory is unlawful. Later, the General Assembly reflects the demand for an end to Israel's unlawful continued presence in the OPT in 12 months.

2025: The Israeli government and Hamas agree to a ceasefire, which takes effect in January. In March, Israel launches renewed air strikes and blocks aid and energy going into Gaza, and in May, it renews full-scale ground operations.

In late September, the Trump administration unveils a twenty-point plan to end the war. Two weeks later, Israel and Hamas agree to its first phase.

2026: Implementation of the second phase remains unstable. Meanwhile, both Israel and Hamas continue to report regular ceasefire violations.

Israel's Actions in Gaza and the West Bank

Understanding developments in Gaza and the West Bank requires looking at the different actors involved, their stated objectives, and the effects of their actions on civilians. Although both areas form part of the Occupied Palestinian Territory, their governing arrangements and security conditions differ.

What is the IDF?

The **Israel Defense Forces (IDF)** are Israel's armed forces, consisting of ground, air, and naval forces. They operate under the authority of the Israeli government. Their stated role is to defend Israel, protect its residents, and maintain national security. The IDF is separate from Israel's civilian government, although the government determines the broader objectives of military operations.

Following the attacks of **7 October 2023**, Israel launched a major military campaign in Gaza. The Israeli government identified its objectives as securing the release of hostages, dismantling Hamas's military and governing capabilities, and preventing further attacks.

Military Operations and Civilian Conditions

In Gaza, the campaign has included air strikes, ground operations, and operations targeting tunnels and other infrastructure identified by Israel as serving military purposes. Israeli authorities have stated that armed groups operating within populated areas create significant challenges for military operations. Such claims require examination against the evidence available for each incident.

UN humanitarian agencies have reported extensive civilian casualties, repeated displacement, and damage to homes, hospitals, schools, and water systems during the conflict. Fighting, restrictions on access, and insecurity have also complicated the delivery of humanitarian assistance. These conditions have placed particular pressure on children, older people, persons with disabilities, and those requiring regular medical treatment.

In the West Bank, Israeli security activities have included raids, arrests, checkpoints, and movement restrictions. Israeli authorities describe these measures as necessary to prevent attacks and address armed activity. UN reporting has also documented civilian casualties, damage to

infrastructure, and difficulties reaching workplaces, schools, and healthcare. Settlement activity and violence involving settlers are additional concerns, distinct from military operations.

Hamas, Other Palestinian Armed Groups, and the Palestinian Authority

Hamas is a Palestinian Islamist political and armed movement that took control of Gaza in 2007. Its armed wing and other Palestinian armed groups participated in the attacks of 7 October, during which civilians and security personnel were killed and hostages were taken. Groups including **Palestinian Islamic Jihad** have also conducted armed operations and rocket attacks against Israel. These organisations have separate leadership structures and should not be treated as representatives of every Palestinian civilian.

The **Palestinian Authority (PA)** is a separate institution that administers parts of the West Bank. Led by Fatah, it manages public services, conducts diplomacy, and maintains security forces. Its security coordination with Israel has been politically contentious among Palestinians. The PA has also faced criticism concerning its accountability, treatment of political opponents, and limited democratic renewal.

For delegates, the central task is to examine how the conduct of each actor affects civilian safety and prospects for peace. Stated security objectives, humanitarian consequences, and compliance with international law should be considered separately. Allegations, findings by investigative bodies, and court judgments must also be clearly distinguished.

Timeline

Background

1979 — the Islamic Republic had formally been established after overthrowing the monarchy. This is the phase in which Iran's relationship with Israel started to change.

1980 - 1988 — Iran was invaded by Iraq, leading to a prolonged war with numerous casualties and severe infrastructural damage.

1982 — Iran's involvement in the Israel-Lebanon conflict contributed to the development of Hezbollah.

2002-2015 — Multiple concerns were raised regarding Iran's nuclear activities. This led to international pressure, resulting in the introduction of the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), which closely monitors the arrangements for Iran's nuclear programme and imposes nuclear-related restrictions.

2018 — The United States officially withdrew from the JCPOA, which intensified tensions over Iran's nuclear programme.

2019-2022 — Several maritime incidents and attacks on Iran with the involvement of Israel impacted stability of the regional environment.

Intensification of the conflict

October 2023 — Following the 7 October attacks led by Hamas and involving other Palestinian armed groups, Iran reiterated its longstanding record of providing Hamas with material, financial and training support.

2024 — An Israeli strike in Damascus led to the death of senior Iranian military commanders.

This resulted in Iran launching direct attacks on Israel using weapons such as drones and missiles.

The attack in April was followed by another attack on Israel during October. Iran's actions triggered Israeli strikes on major military targets as a retaliation.

2025 — Israel launched strikes on Iran, primarily targeting military facilities and nuclear sites. This conflict lasted for twelve days, resulting in casualties, infrastructure damage and raised concerns on civilian protection.

The United States had joined this conflict, launching strikes at the Iranian nuclear facilities. Soon after, on 24 June 2025, a ceasefire was effective, temporarily pausing the serious phase of continuous attacks.

Escalations in the Humanitarian Situation in Iran

28 February 2026 — Large scale strikes were launched on Iran by the United States and Israel, making the conflict much wider. These attacks, with the immediate retaliation by Iran had imposed serious risks on the civilians and other essential services. A strike hit the Shajareh Tayyebeh school in Minab. This incident raised major concerns due to the large number of deaths reported, regarding accountability and compliance with international humanitarian law.

March 2026 — The World Health Organisation (WHO) had reported that the conflict had killed multiple civilians, including children, military personnel and health workers, along with severe damage to healthcare facilities. This large-scale damage has disrupted access to healthcare.

Additional factors such as difficulties in accessing essential supplies (electricity, fuel, food, water and shelter) resulted in mass displacement.

Mid-2026 — Disruption to maritime routes and transport services affected the movement of medical equipment and other humanitarian supplies. Furthermore, reports by the Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United Nations have stated that the increase in prices of basic commodities have reduced the purchasing power of families.

October 2026 — There have been stalled negotiations over reopening the Strait of Hormuz and regional security between Iran and the United States, while military escalations continue to persist.

Recent Military Escalations Involving Iran

Military tensions involving Iran have become an important part of the wider regional situation. For many years, confrontation between Iran and Israel largely involved covert operations, cyberattacks, and clashes involving allied armed groups. Direct exchanges between the two States marked a significant change, increasing concerns about civilian safety and the possibility of a wider war.

Direct Exchanges in 2024

A major escalation followed the **1 April 2024 strike on an Iranian diplomatic compound in Damascus, Syria**, attributed to Israel. The strike killed senior Iranian military personnel. Iran described the incident as an attack on its sovereignty and diplomatic premises.

On **13 and 14 April**, Iran launched a large drone and missile attack towards Israel. Iran stated that it was responding to the Damascus strike. Israel and supporting countries intercepted most of the incoming weapons. The UN Secretary-General called for restraint, warning that further exchanges could draw the region into a broader conflict.

Another round followed in **October 2024**. Iran launched missiles towards Israel on 1 October. On 26 October, Israel conducted strikes against sites in Iran that it identified as military targets, including missile-related facilities and air defence systems. Israel described its operation as a response to the earlier Iranian attack. These exchanges demonstrated how quickly an action and the response to it could produce further escalation.

The June 2025 Conflict

The confrontation intensified on **13 June 2025**, when Israel began a major series of strikes in Iran. Israeli authorities described the operation as addressing threats associated with Iran's nuclear and missile programmes. Iran maintained that its nuclear programme was peaceful and responded with missile and drone attacks against Israel.

During the fighting, nuclear facilities became a particular concern. The **International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)**, the organisation responsible for international nuclear monitoring, reported damage at Iranian nuclear sites. On 22 June, the United States also struck facilities at Fordow, Natanz, and Isfahan.

A ceasefire took effect on **24 June**, following twelve days of conflict. It brought a pause in the fighting, but disagreements over security, nuclear activities, and international monitoring remained unresolved.

Further Escalation in 2026

On **28 February 2026**, the United States and Israel launched another major military operation against Iran. Iranian responses included strikes towards Israel and countries in the Gulf region. The UN Secretary-General warned of the danger of further regional expansion and called on all parties to protect civilians and pursue diplomatic solutions.

In early April, the United States and Iran announced a two-week ceasefire. The UN welcomed the announcement, while stressing the need for continued negotiations. The temporary arrangement illustrated the importance of diplomacy, but also the difficulty of turning a pause in military operations into a lasting agreement.

Relevance to the Agenda

These developments raise questions about civilian protection, nuclear safety, and the conduct of military operations across borders. Damage to essential infrastructure can affect healthcare, transport, and access to basic services, even beyond the immediate area of an attack.

For delegates, it is important to distinguish the explanations offered by each government from independently established facts and legal findings. Claims of self-defence require examination under the UN Charter, while the conduct of hostilities must also be assessed under international humanitarian law. The protection of civilians remains an obligation for every party involved.

Regional Impact

The conflict in the Occupied Palestinian Territory and the military escalations involving Iran have consequences across the Middle East. Countries are connected through trade, borders, diplomatic relationships, and security agreements. As a result, fighting in one area can affect the safety and stability of neighbouring States, even when they are not directly involved.

Regional Security

One major concern is the possibility of fighting spreading across additional borders. Exchanges between Israel and Hezbollah have affected communities in both Lebanon and northern Israel. UN reporting has documented displacement, damage to civilian property, and disruption to daily life on both sides of the Blue Line, the UN-marked line of Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon.

Direct military exchanges between Iran and Israel have added another dimension to regional insecurity. Each new attack can create pressure for a response, making it harder to contain the conflict. Neighbouring governments must then consider how to protect their populations, borders, and essential infrastructure while avoiding further involvement.

The role of armed groups also complicates the situation. Iran maintains relationships with several groups in the region, but these groups have their own leadership and interests. Their actions should therefore be assessed individually rather than treated as the policy of an entire country or population.

Diplomacy and Relations between States

Regional governments face the difficult task of addressing security concerns while responding to civilian suffering and maintaining diplomatic relationships. Their approaches differ according to their borders, domestic concerns, and relationships with the parties involved.

Egypt and Qatar, working with the United States, have played important roles in negotiations concerning ceasefires, hostage releases, and humanitarian access in Gaza. Such efforts show why communication remains necessary even when the parties strongly disagree. Negotiations can produce practical arrangements that reduce immediate suffering without resolving every political dispute.

Escalations involving Iran also increase the importance of diplomatic channels. When communication breaks down, uncertainty about another State's intentions can increase the risk of miscalculation. Maintaining contact can help clarify positions and prevent an incident from developing into a wider confrontation.

Trade and Economic Pressure

The economic effects extend beyond areas experiencing direct fighting. Attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea have led shipping companies to use longer routes around Africa. According to UN Trade and Development, these disruptions have increased transport costs and delayed deliveries.

For countries and businesses dependent on imported goods, longer journeys can mean higher costs for fuel, food, and other supplies. Disruption to shipping through the Suez Canal also

affects Egypt's revenue. These pressures can reach households that are far from the conflict itself.

Further escalation involving Iran creates risks for regional energy supplies and transport routes. The scale of the economic impact depends on where fighting occurs, how long it continues, and whether commercial routes remain accessible.

For delegates, regional stability involves more than preventing another military confrontation. It also requires preserving diplomatic communication, protecting trade routes, and supporting cooperation between neighbouring States. These measures help limit the wider effects of conflict while longer-term political issues remain under discussion.

Cross-Border Humanitarian Impact of Military Operations

The humanitarian effects of military operations do not stop at national borders. People may seek safety or medical treatment in another country, while aid organisations depend on crossings, roads, and airports to deliver assistance. Neighbouring communities can therefore become part of the humanitarian response even when they are outside the main area of fighting.

Displacement and the Search for Safety

Displacement means being forced to leave home because of conflict or danger. Some people move to another part of their own country, while others cross an international border. These situations create different needs, but both can involve losing access to housing, employment, education, and family support.

During the escalation in Lebanon in 2024, UNHCR reported that Lebanese citizens and Syrian refugees crossed into Syria. Some Syrians had previously fled to Lebanon to escape conflict and were displaced again. Their experience shows that crossing a border does not necessarily mean finding lasting safety.

Escalations involving Iran also raise concerns for people already displaced. Iran hosts a large Afghan population, including refugees. In June 2025, UNHCR warned that further fighting between Iran and Israel could create additional displacement in a region already supporting substantial refugee populations.

Medical Evacuations and Healthcare

When local hospitals cannot provide the treatment patients need, medical evacuation may become essential. Patients from Gaza have received care in countries including Egypt, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates, with support from the World Health Organization and its partners.

These transfers require more than an available hospital bed. Patients need approval to travel, safe transport, medical records, and coordination between authorities. Children and seriously ill patients may also require an accompanying family member. Delays can interrupt cancer treatment, surgery, rehabilitation, or care for chronic illnesses.

Receiving countries contribute staff, equipment, and hospital capacity. International funding helps them meet these additional needs while continuing to provide services for their own populations.

Humanitarian Supplies and Border Access

Food, medicine, fuel, and emergency shelter materials often pass through neighbouring countries before reaching affected communities. Their delivery depends on functioning crossings, security arrangements, inspections, and safe routes.

Authorities may introduce checks for security purposes, while humanitarian organisations must ensure that assistance reaches people in time. When crossings close or routes become unsafe, deliveries can be delayed even when supplies are available nearby. Effective coordination is therefore essential to connect aid arriving at a border with the people who need it.

Pressure on Families and Host Communities

Communities receiving displaced people may face increased demand for housing, schools, water, and healthcare. Support should reach both newcomers and local residents so that limited resources do not become a source of tension.

Families can also become separated during evacuation or displacement. Missing documents, interrupted schooling, and uncertainty about returning home can make recovery harder. Children, older people, and persons with disabilities may need additional assistance throughout this process.

For this agenda, cross-border humanitarian cooperation means keeping medical transfers, relief deliveries, and protection services accessible. It also means supporting neighbouring countries so that the responsibility for assisting civilians does not fall on them alone.

Domestic Human Rights Situation

Human rights concerns during conflict extend beyond military operations. They also involve how people are treated by public authorities, whether they can express their views, and whether they have access to justice and essential services. For this agenda, these questions apply to the Occupied Palestinian Territory, Israel, and Iran, although their political and legal circumstances differ.

Rights in the Occupied Palestinian Territory

Palestinians live under different systems of authority. Israel exercises control through the occupation, while the Palestinian Authority administers parts of the West Bank. Hamas has exercised authority in Gaza since 2007, although military operations have disrupted its governing capacity. Assessing responsibility requires identifying which authority controls the action or situation being examined.

UN human rights reporting has raised concerns about detention, freedom of movement, access to legal assistance, and the protection of journalists and civil society. These issues affect daily life. A movement restriction may prevent someone from reaching work or medical treatment, while detention without adequate safeguards can leave families uncertain about a relative's whereabouts or legal position.

The UN Human Rights Office has also reported concerns about the treatment of journalists, political opponents, and critics by Palestinian authorities. Its recommendations address multiple actors, including Israel, the Palestinian Authority, Hamas, and other armed groups. Delegates should distinguish between allegations, documented findings, and decisions made by courts.

Rights and Public Debate in Israel

Within Israel, relevant questions include the protection of civilians, freedom of expression, peaceful assembly, and the treatment of people in custody. Public debate during wartime can involve disagreements over military policy, government decisions, and the needs of affected families.

Security concerns may lead authorities to introduce restrictions. However, such measures remain subject to legal safeguards and review. The impact on minority communities, journalists, and people expressing unpopular opinions is important when assessing whether rights are protected equally.

OHCHR reporting on detention connected to the Gaza conflict has raised concerns about the treatment of Palestinian detainees in Israeli custody. Such reports should be considered alongside

official responses and available investigative findings, without assuming that every allegation has the same evidentiary status.

Rights in Iran

UN reporting on Iran has identified concerns involving freedom of expression, peaceful protest, fair trials, the death penalty, and the treatment of women and minority communities. A UN fact-finding mission reported in 2025 that women and girls continued to face discrimination, including through enforcement of mandatory dress requirements.

Military escalation adds further questions about access to information, emergency measures, and the ability of people to seek assistance or challenge official decisions. National security concerns do not remove the need for lawful detention procedures, fair treatment, and protection against torture.

Common Standards

Across these settings, delegates should examine whether people can obtain legal assistance, report mistreatment, and receive an effective remedy. Emergency restrictions must have a legal basis and meet the applicable requirements of necessity and proportionality.

A neutral approach means applying these standards consistently while recognising differences in authority, evidence, and circumstances. It also means keeping the rights of individuals separate from opinions about their government or political leadership.

Key International Actors

The ongoing conflict in Iran has drawn involvement from various states, international organisations, and regional bodies. The above mentioned actors play different roles in shaping the humanitarian aspects of the highlighted situations. Understanding the roles and responsibilities of the following actors is essential in order to assess the international response to the crisis and further proposing solutions and underlining areas which specially require international cooperation.

States Directly Involved

A) Israel : Israel plays the central role in launching a major military campaign against Iran, mainly targeting its leadership, nuclear infrastructure and ballistic missile systems. The conflict has nevertheless created several humanitarian concerns regarding the large number of civilian casualties, and damage to infrastructure.

B) Iran : When the United States and Israeli air strikes targeted Iranian military infrastructures and leadership, Iran retaliates with counter drone strikes against the United States and other allies across the Middle East. Moreover, this conflict has amplified the displacement of civilians, especially from seriously affected areas. Extensive damage was reported to residencies, healthcare infrastructure and other civilian facilities. The escalation has greatly affected neighbouring states and disrupted regional transport.

Major Diplomatic Actors

A) The United States of America : The United States remains another major actor throughout the conflict. On the 28th of February 2026, the United States launched multiple strikes, specifically targeting Iranian leadership. Furthermore, Human Rights Organisations and Documentation groups highlighted the civilian tolls from the joint campaign. The actions carried out by the United States in cooperation with Israel resulted in multiple civilian casualties and infrastructure damage, mass displacement, along with concerns raised with respect to the legal and international law.
B) Egypt : Egypt makes use of its General Intelligence Service to relay messages and facilitate back channel conversations for ceasefire between the United States, Israel, and Iran. Bound by a historical peace treaty, Egypt maintains a cautious, non-belligerent stance towards Israel. Since Egypt is a close neighbour to Gaza, it serves as a primary hub for humanitarian aid delivery.
C) Qatar : Qatar's involvement can be defined by its diplomatic mediation, quality infrastructure and great economic impacts. Qatar, while being a close ally with Pakistan, acts as a primary intermediary for indirect conversations between Washington and Tehran. Additionally. Qatar actively works upon de-escalation frameworks to restore freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz. Israel directly launched strikes on Qatari sites, and strategically targeted senior Hamas political leaders meeting in Doha.
D) Jordan : Jordan is one of the two Arab countries bound to Israel by a peace treaty. It guards Israel's longest land border and hosts nearly 4,000 US troops as a forward platform for Western counterterrorism. Jordan, for many years has regarded Iran as a malign regional actor, yet it did not seek this war as a conflict had the potential to majorly impact the country's stability. This conflict created internal public anxiety, protests and severe economic strains in Jordan.
E) Turkey : Turkey has always maintained active neutrality, and refused to join the military campaign by the United States and Israel against Iran. The Turkish officials have expressed deep concerns, stating that a sudden collapse in Iran could trigger a massive refugee influx. However, Turkish infrastructure and public finances are not sufficient to host a sudden wave of displaced people, especially after witnessing the Syrian civil war.
F) India : India has been maintaining a constant, neutral stance in the Israel-United States-Iran conflict. India has been balancing its relationship with the Gulf countries,

Israel and the United States strategically. Additionally, the ministry of external affairs have launched evacuation operations to protect nearly 10,000 Indian students and professionals in Iran.

G) The European Union : After a meeting with the Foreign affairs council, the European Union established a consensus not to engage in military operations against Iran. Additionally, the European Commission mobilised approximately 510 million USD as emergency humanitarian aid to the regional impact of the conflict, especially in buffer areas.

United Nations and Humanitarian Organisations

A) The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) and The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) : The UNHRC and OHCHR, along with its independent mechanisms have played a crucial role in closely monitoring, documenting and reporting the International Humanitarian Law violations arising out of the military escalations in Iran.

B) The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UNOCHA) : OCHA regularly publishes detailed reports and situational updates to track the infrastructure damage, and coordinate inter-agency responses across multiple sectors. OCHA has also activated several regional frameworks to manage the spillover effects of the crisis.

C) The World Health Organisation (WHO) : WHO has actively been coordinating medical and public health responses to manage the increasing number of casualties and has provided trauma kits, medical equipment, and vital surgical supplies to numerous hospitals and emergency treatment centres.

D) The United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) : UNICEF has actively played a role in addressing all parties involved in the conflict to uphold the International Humanitarian Law and protect civil infrastructure. It is also focusing heavily on child protection, especially after the incident in late February 2026, when thousands of children were killed, injured and displaced.

International Legal Institutions :

★ The International Commission of Jurists : The International Commission of Jurists has formally condemned the air strikes carried out against Iran by the United States and Israel. The body had also raised several concerns regarding the high-precision air strikes hitting sensitive areas like educational institutions, and other nuclear facilities.

Current Humanitarian Situation

The ongoing military escalations in the Occupied Palestine Territories (OPT) have caused several humanitarian concerns such as casualties, displacements, damage to civilian infrastructure and multiple disturbances in healthcare and other essential supplies. It is therefore very important to deeply understand and analyse the current humanitarian situation in both the regions.

- ★ **Humanitarian Situation in the Occupied Palestinian Territory**
  - The OPT is still facing severe humanitarian funding shortfalls, followed by widespread displacements. The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UNOCHA) states that these funding shortfalls have caused shrinkage in the number of hot meals produced everyday, contributing to the conflict majorly, as families continue to struggle for other basic necessities.
  - Food insecurity remains a serious concern. Many households are still dependent on Humanitarian aid to meet their needs. During September 2026, food assistance reached nearly 2,20,000 households in Gaza. Though each household received food parcels, along with a good amount of flour, this covered just 50% of the minimum food requirements. This, accompanied by insufficient funds have forced humanitarian organisations to cut down the number of people who are actually receiving their nutrition.
  - There remain multiple disturbances in the distributions of healthcare, fuel and clean water throughout the region. The World Health Organisation warned that such delays may lower the rate of treatment of the injured, further causing devastating health consequences.
  - Thousands of Palestinian citizens have been killed by the Israeli forces since October 2023. This was accompanied by destruction of infrastructure in 2026, leading to displacement of Palestinians. Nearly 2,79,000 out of the displaced people are residing in over 400 flood prone areas and over 2,300 unsafe buildings.
  - Amidst all of this, children's safety has been a major topic of discussion. With mass displacement and disruptions in infrastructure, children have lost their access to safe learning environments. Additionally, displacements have made shelters overcrowded, decreasing the sanitation levels. This makes the children more prone to health issues. Humanitarian organisations are still unable to provide space learning spaces and psychological support for the affected children.

★ **Humanitarian Situation in Iran**

- There have been severe infrastructural damages caused by the heavy military strikes. The most impacted spaces remain schools, healthcare facilities, power grids and energy facilities. The increasing number of civilian casualties and displacements have pressurised healthcare institutions and emergency response services. WHO, in its report published in March 2026 has clearly mentioned that there have been approximately 1,825 deaths (not strictly civilian), 23,061 injuries and nearly 3.2 million displaced Iranians.
- The attack on the Shajareh Tayyabeh primary school in Minab (on the 28th February) still remains extremely terrifying, with nearly 160 people killed, most of them being children. This incident has raised several questions regarding the protection of educational institutions and children during such armed conflicts.
- The trade restrictions have created disturbances in the import and distribution of essential supplies and pharmaceuticals, including shipping around the Strait of Hormuz. Such disturbances have majorly impacted the transport and prices of fuel, food and multiple other humanitarian supplies.
- Additionally, high inflation, currency instability, trade disruptions and other economic strains have further complicated the household purchasing power, restricting civilians to bring home essential commodities such as food and water.

The United Nations Frameworks and Resolutions

The United Nations frameworks and treaties play a crucial role in assessing the situation, protecting civilians, military personnel, healthcare assistants, and in providing essential rules to limit suffering during armed conflicts. The UN treaties, documents and resolutions mandate accountability of the parties involved and create peace mechanisms during such escalations. Multilateral treaties restrict or ban armed weapons that have the potential to cause long term sufferings. Thus, learning about the essential frameworks will strengthen your understanding of the legal obligations posed on the parties involved in the armed conflict.

I.The UN Treaties and Frameworks

★ **The United Nations Charter (1945) :** The UN Charter is the foundational treaty of the United Nations, and it binds all member states. It was signed on June 26, 1945 and entered into force on October 24, 1945. There are three main pillars which have been established by the UN Charter. They are : Peace and Security, Human Rights, and Development. The UN Charter states that all members are legally equal and promotes

sovereign equality. It also promotes non-intervention, that means that the UN cannot intervene in matters that fall under a country's domestic jurisdiction. Furthermore, it fosters friendly relations among nations and encourages peaceful resolution of conflicts.

★ **The Geneva Conventions (1949) :** The Geneva Conventions are a series of four international treaties adopted on August 12, 1949. They form the core of the International Humanitarian Law. They play a key role in limiting the adverse effects of armed conflicts and in the protection of wounded soldiers, prisoners of war, and civilians who are no longer a part of hostilities. The four conventions are as follow :

- Convention (I) - it contains 64 articles which provide protection for the wounded and sick in the armed forces. It also recognises medical personnel, religious personnel, medical units and medical transports.
- Convention (II) - this convention contains 63 articles for the protection of wounded, sick and shipwrecked members of the armed forces at sea. These articles provide specific protection for hospital ships, coastal rescue crafts, medical aircraft and other medical transports at sea, as well as religious, medical and hospital personnel performing their duties in a naval context.
- Convention (III) - it contains 143 articles. It is the international treaty that defines humanitarian protection of legal rights for prisoners of war (POW). It states that captors must protect POWs from acts of violence, torture and insults.
- Convention (IV) - this convention contains 158 articles and was the first multilateral treaty which was entirely focused on protection of civilians during armed conflicts. It states that all civilians and personnel must be treated humanely, regardless of colour, religion, faith, birth, wealth, or any similar criteria.

★ **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR, 1948) :** the UDHR is a document adopted by the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) on December 10, 1948. It enlists some of the rights and freedoms of all human beings. It forms the broader foundation for human rights. It sets out all the fundamental civil, political, economic, social, and cultural rights which must be protected universally for everyone. The rights that were included continue to form the basis for international human rights law.

★ **International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR, 1966) :** it is a multilateral treaty which was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly on December 16, 1966 that makes civil and political rights legally binding. The core rights protected by the covenant are: the right to life and freedom from death, torture and slavery; humane treatment in detention and fair trial rights; freedom of thought and expression; equal protection before the law.

★ **International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR, 1966) :** it was adopted by the UN General Assembly in 1966 and in force since 1976, is a core international human rights treaty that obligates States to recognize and progressively realize a broad range of economic, social, and cultural rights. These include the rights to work, fair wages, safe working conditions, social security, family protection, an adequate standard of living (including food, clothing, and housing), health, education, and participation in cultural life.

II.The UN Resolutions on the Occupied Palestine Territories

★ **The UN Security Council Resolution 2720 (2023) :** It was adopted on December 22, 2023 for the protection of civilians and enabling immediate humanitarian access to Palestinians in Gaza. It called for increasing aid for the crisis, including food, fuel and medical supply provisions. 13 members gave their approval for the resolution, while Russia and the United States abstained from voting.

★ **The UN Security Council Resolution 2334 (2016) :** It was adopted on 23 December 2016. It concerns the Israeli settlements in Palestine territories which were occupied since 1967, including East Jerusalem. It demanded a complete discontinuation of settlement activities in the OPT, reaffirming that such settlements are a serious violation of the Human Rights Law. 14 members voted for this resolution, while the United States abstained from voting.

★ **The HRC Resolution A/HRC/RES/61/4 (2026) :** The resolution titled "*Human rights situation in the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem, and the obligation to ensure accountability and justice"* was adopted on March 27, 2026. This resolution focuses extensively on the accountability and justice for violations of IHRL in the Occupied Palestine Territories, including East Jerusalem.

★ **ICJ Advisory Opinion of 19 July 2024 :** The advisory opinion issued by the International Court of Justice addresses the legal consequences arising from Israel's policies and practices in OPT, including East Jerusalem. The ICJ concluded that Israel's presence in OPT is against the law. Furthermore, Israeli measures were found to breach Article 3 of The International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (ICERD). The court had noted that exploiting natural resources in OPT breaches Israel's obligations under the IHL.

★ **HRC Resolution S-30/1 (2021) and the Commission of Inquiry (COI) :** This resolution was adopted on May 27, 2021, establishing an independent, international Commission of Inquiry to investigate the violations of the International Humanitarian Law and the International Human Rights Law, especially in the regions of occupied Palestine and in Israel.

Questions A Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

1. What steps can be taken to protect women and children in conflict zones from sexual and gender based violence?

2. What are the measures that can be introduced to protect essential civilian infrastructure such as healthcare centres, schools, and refugee camps during regional escalations?

3. How can the UN ensure that all parties involved in the armed conflict comply with International Humanitarian Law, regardless of the power they hold?

4. What kinds of mechanisms can be developed for the protection and safety of children, military personnel, healthcare workers, displaced persons, and people with disabilities during armed conflict?

5. How can the international community establish transparent systems to monitor the delivery of essential humanitarian supplies without interruption?

6. What mechanisms could potentially avoid human rights violations in crisis zones from developing into entrenched systemic issues?

7. Who should bear the responsibility for the reconstruction of damaged civilian infrastructure? Should there be an independent committee to handle the reparation and rehabilitation of the damaged infrastructure and affected civilians?

8. How can the UN promote accountability for the violations by the involved parties when political alliances restrict international investigations?

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